thousand residents, that was quite a feat—every fourth inhabitant of Sofia was there to see the mayor present Khrushchev with the symbolic gift of a key to the city gates. Sofia, Varna, and Pleven bestowed the title of honorary citizen on the Soviet guest.

No member of the Soviet party Presidium accompanied him on the trip, making Khrushchev the sole object of attention and adulation. One of the photos taken during the five-day visit showed Khrushchev in a light-colored suit standing out against Soviet and Bulgarian officials in dark suits, for all the world like a white-robed communist pope surrounded by a throng of black-clad bishops. And Khrushchev's visit had all the trappings of a religious ritual, not unlike a papal visit to a heavily Catholic country. It was a celebration of communism, Slavic brotherhood, and, more than anything else, the personal power and infallibility of the man at the center of it all—Nikita Khrushchev, the high priest of the world communist movement.[1]

"And where is communism now?" asked Khrushchev rhetorically, addressing festively clad crowds of peasants in the village of Obnova (meaning "Renovation"), a showcase of socialist agriculture in northern Bulgaria. And he answered in grandiose fashion: "Communism has broadened its boundaries. And if, not long ago, the Soviet Union was the only socialist country, the socialist camp has now broadly expanded its boundaries, uniting in one fraternal family many socialist countries of Europe, the Chinese People's Republic, the Korean People's Democratic Republic, and the Democratic Republic of Vietnam. Postwar Europe found itself missing many states that had gone socialist. Now the banner of socialism waves proudly over Cuba."[2]

Cuba was constantly on Khrushchev's mind throughout his Bulgarian trip. For all the ritual atmosphere of triumph, he felt deeply insecure. "While I was on the official visit to Bulgaria," recalled Khrushchev later, "one thought kept hammering away at my brain: 'what will happen if we lose Cuba?' " The possibility of another American-backed invasion gave him no rest. "We had to think up some way of confronting America with more than words," remembered Khrushchev. "We had to establish a tangible and effective deterrent to American interference in the Caribbean, but what exactly?"[3]